

ISL

chaos breeds new heroes

Amid off-field turmoil, Mumbai City and emerging Indian forwards **keep the season alive** with standout performances.

Neeladri Bhattacharjee
neeladri.b@thehindu.co.in

The Indian Super League's (ISL) uncertainty has resulted in several casualties, including job cuts, changes in player contracts, and financial woes for most franchises. One that made the most headlines, unsurprisingly, was the City Football Group's withdrawal from Mumbai City FC. The conglomerate, which owns 18 clubs around the world, withdrew its stake amid the league's nebulous future.

But instead of capitulating into a downward spiral, Mumbai City has continued to perform consistently, including a 1-0 win over defending champion Mohun Bagan Super Giant, ascending to the top of the table after eight rounds.

The most significant ingredient in its form has been its Indian forwards.

Lallianzuala Chhangte (**below**) — a player once touted to be Sunil Chhetri's heir apparent

as India's premier striker in 2024 — leads the scoring charts this ISL season with three match-winning goals in eight matches.

"I came into this season to be successful as a team first. I know the goals will come because I work hard every day and my confidence is high. Winning individual awards would be special, but my ambition is to win trophies," Chhangte said.

He is followed by winger Noufal P.N., who has found the net twice. Half of Mumbai City's points after eight rounds (nine from 18) have come through this duo, even though the club's conventional striker is a foreigner, Jorge Pereyra Diaz.

Winds of change

Another subplot of a fresh beginning has been that of Sporting Club Delhi, a club that shifted base from Hyderabad this season. Tomasz Tchórz had a nightmarish stint as

